

Hardware & Networking

Carrier Capex Tracker: Telco and Cable/Broadband CapEx Outlooks Unchanged; 2Q26 Spending In-Line with Expectations

Key takeaways from Telco and Cable/Broadband 2Q26 earnings: In Telco, T is becoming more aggressive in pursuing fiber market share, with Fiber ARPU flat y/y (*excluding Lumen*) as the company sacrifices broadband revenue to maximize combined fiber and wireless revenue instead (*i.e. convergence*). Together, T and VZ reiterated their intentions to rapidly scale their fiber footprints, while TMUS continued to refrain from establishing a fiber passings target in pursuit of convergence or scale alone, and instead emphasized its focus on ROI. Notably, VZ announced a \$1 bn+ Google dark-fiber contract in 2Q, with additional deals expected to represent multiple billions of dollars in revenue over the next several years, providing another proof point for the demand for long-haul/metro fiber and data center interconnect. In Cable/Broadband, CMCSA shared that promotional intensity is increasing in some markets, some of which it characterized as “irrational.” The company observed broadband downstream traffic up +10% y/y and upstream traffic up +25% y/y, attributing some of the traffic growth to AI queries. The company believes that even though it is less economical to run, an active hybrid-fiber coaxial (HFC) network may have advantages relative to passive fiber in an AI-driven world. Lastly, CHTR’s competitive fiber overbuild outlook was largely unchanged, with the pace of fiber overbuild growth continuing as typical and no structural change observed in the level of promotional activity in the broadband market. **Net-net, additional fiber passings remain supported by Telco’s footprint-expansion and market-share objectives, with convergence improving total account economics while pressuring pricing for cable operators as they continue upgrading their HFC networks.**

*We are updating our capex tracker for recent earnings reports from Telecom Service providers, including AT&T, T-Mobile, and Verizon, and Cable/Broadband operators, including Charter and Comcast. **Aggregate capex for US Telecom Service Providers** increased +13% y/y for 2Q26, modestly better than JPM expectations of +12% y/y. FY26 outlooks were reaffirmed across the board, implying that the recovery from 2024 (-8% y/y) continues following 2025 (+2% y/y), with an expected aggregate FY26 capex growth of +2% y/y to ~\$50 bn (largely in-line with JPM analyst expectations heading into the earnings season). Among telecom service providers, Verizon remains focused on cost reductions and running lean operations, and its reiterated 2026 capex guidance represents a ~\$4 bn y/y reduction in capex if including Frontier in the 2025 compare. **Meanwhile, aggregate capex growth for Cable/Broadband operators** registered an increase of +8% y/y for 2Q26, better than JPM expectations of +2% y/y. For 2026, aggregate capex continues to be projected at ~\$20 bn implying a -1% y/y decline, and compares to +4% delivered in 2025 and +1% in 2024. While the capex outlooks from both Telco and Cable/Broadband operators remain resilient, we expect to see upside surprises from the Cable/Broadband operators group in 2026, as we saw in 2025 as well, with competitive pressures and network infrastructure upgrades to deliver high service levels remaining a priority. That said, the long-term outlook will be weighed by Charter aiming to achieve <\$8 bn capex in 2028, relative to ~\$11.5 bn annually today. **The aggregate of the outlooks, both near-term and medium-term, imply that while spend towards networks from broadband***

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and telco companies remains robust at this time, the drivers will likely remain cyclical with limited visibility into secular increases long-term.

For the US Telecom Service Providers – AT&T, T-Mobile, and Verizon aggregate capex was +13% y/y at \$12.8 bn in 2Q26, above JPMe of \$12.7 bn, heading into the print. According to JPM analyst forecasts, aggregate capex plans for 3Q26 are now expected to track +3% y/y to ~\$12.6 bn, compared to the prior estimate of +5% y/y to \$12.8 bn.

Looking to full-year 2026, all three providers reiterated their full-year capex outlooks, with AT&T at \$23-\$24 bn, T-Mobile at ~\$10 bn, and Verizon at \$16.0-\$16.5 bn. These outlooks were largely in-line with expectations: JPM analyst forecasts now estimate that aggregate capex growth for FY26 will track to +2% y/y to \$49.7 bn, compared to prior estimates of +2% y/y to \$50.0 bn, with AT&T capex expected to track to -3% y/y (unchanged), T-Mobile -2% y/y (from flat y/y), and Verizon +7% y/y (unchanged).

For the US Cable & Broadband Operators – Charter and Comcast capex in aggregate rose +8% y/y to ~\$5.2 bn in 2Q26, better than JPMe of \$4.9 bn heading into the print. JPM's forecast for aggregate capex plans for 3Q26 remained unchanged, expected to track to -2% y/y to \$5.1 bn relative to prior estimates of -2% y/y to \$5.1 bn.

Looking to full-year 2026, Charter maintained its FY26 capex guide at ~\$11.4 bn (-2% y/y), while Comcast did not comment on capex guidance, having previously shared that it expects 2026 capex should be similar to 2025 with JPM modeling \$8.8 bn (+1% y/y). As a result, per JPM analyst forecasts, 2026 aggregate capex is still expected to moderate slightly by -1% y/y to \$20 bn.

Note: Companies referenced in this report are covered by Sebastiano Petti. Please see detailed carrier capex forecasts on Page 2.

Latest Carrier Capex Forecasts

Figure 1: Carrier Capex Historicals and Forecasts

\$ in Millions

U.S. Telcos	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Verizon	4,145	3,808	4,310	4,748	17,011	4,201	4,009	4,150	4,140	16,500	4,100	4,200	4,100	4,100	16,500	4,225	4,325	4,225	4,225	17,000
AT&T	4,480	5,117	5,287	7,139	22,023	5,089	6,131	6,140	6,140	23,500	5,850	5,650	6,150	5,850	23,500	5,950	5,550	6,150	5,850	23,500
T-Mobile	2,451	2,396	2,639	2,469	9,955	2,623	2,703	2,270	2,135	9,731	2,433	2,467	2,342	2,392	9,635	2,455	2,486	2,366	2,413	9,721
U.S. Telcos	11,076	11,321	12,236	14,356	48,989	11,913	12,843	12,560	12,415	49,731	12,383	12,317	12,592	12,342	49,635	12,630	12,361	12,741	12,488	50,221
Y/Y Change	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Verizon	-5%	3%	9%	-6%	0%	1%	5%	-4%	-13%	-3%	-2%	5%	-1%	-1%	0%	3%	3%	3%	3%	3%
AT&T	-3%	4%	-4%	1%	0%	14%	20%	16%	-14%	7%	15%	-8%	0%	-5%	0%	2%	-2%	0%	0%	0%
T-Mobile	-7%	17%	35%	12%	13%	7%	13%	-14%	-14%	-2%	-7%	-9%	3%	12%	-1%	1%	1%	1%	1%	1%
U.S. Telcos	-5%	6%	7%	0%	2%	8%	13%	-14%	-14%	2%	4%	-4%	0%	-1%	0%	2%	0%	1%	1%	1%
Q/Q Change	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Verizon	-18%	-8%	13%	10%		-12%	-5%	4%	0%		-1%	2%	-2%	0%		3%	2%	-2%	0%	
AT&T	-37%	14%	3%	35%		-29%	20%	0%	0%		-5%	-3%	9%	-5%		2%	-7%	11%	-5%	
T-Mobile	11%	-2%	10%	-6%		6%	3%	-16%	-6%		14%	1%	-5%	2%		3%	1%	-5%	2%	
U.S. Telcos	-23%	2%	8%	17%		-17%	8%	-2%	-1%		0%	-1%	2%	-2%		2%	-2%	3%	-2%	

Cable Operators	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Comcast	1,630	1,914	2,326	2,855	8,725	1,848	2,294	2,270	2,392	8,804	2,165	2,149	2,147	2,167	8,628	2,171	2,156	2,165	2,194	8,686
Charter	2,399	2,874	3,051	3,335	11,659	2,855	2,871	2,787	2,929	11,442	2,441	2,422	2,401	2,249	9,512	2,032	2,015	2,029	2,043	8,119
Cable Operators	4,029	4,788	5,377	6,190	20,384	4,703	5,165	5,056	5,322	20,246	4,606	4,570	4,548	4,415	18,140	4,202	4,172	4,194	4,237	16,806
Y/Y Change	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Comcast	-14%	3%	19%	10%	5%	13%	20%	-2%	-16%	1%	17%	-6%	-5%	-9%	-2%	0%	0%	1%	1%	1%
Charter	-14%	1%	19%	9%	3%	19%	0%	-9%	-12%	-2%	-15%	-16%	-14%	-23%	-17%	-17%	-17%	-15%	-9%	-15%
Cable Operators	-14%	2%	19%	9%	4%	17%	8%	-6%	-14%	-1%	-2%	-12%	-10%	-17%	-10%	-9%	-9%	-8%	-4%	-7%
Q/Q Change	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Comcast	-37%	17%	22%	23%		-35%	24%	-1%	5%		-9%	-1%	0%	1%		0%	-1%	0%	1%	
Charter	-22%	20%	6%	9%		-14%	1%	-3%	5%		-17%	-1%	-1%	-6%		-10%	-1%	1%	1%	
Cable Operators	-29%	19%	12%	15%		-24%	10%	-2%	5%		-13%	-1%	0%	-3%		-5%	-1%	1%	1%	

Source: Company reports and J.P. Morgan estimates. Capex forecasts are based on estimates from JPM Telecom Services team.

Figure 2: Aggregate Carrier Capex Historicals and Forecasts

\$ in Millions

U.S. Telcos	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Y/Y % Change	-5%	6%	7%	0%	2%	8%	13%	3%	-14%	2%	4%	-4%	0%	-1%	0%	3%	-2%	3%	-75%	1%
Q/Q % Change	-23%	2%	8%	17%		-17%	8%	-2%	-1%		0%	-1%	2%	-2%		-75%	-2%	3%	-2%	
Cable Operators	1Q25	2Q25	3Q25	4Q25	2025	1Q26	2Q26	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Y/Y % Change	-14%	2%	19%	9%	4%	17%	8%	-6%	-14%	-1%	-2%	-12%	-10%	-17%	-10%	-8%	-8%	-5%	-77%	-7%
Q/Q % Change	-29%	19%	12%	15%		-24%	10%	-2%	5%		-13%	-1%	0%	-3%		-77%	-1%	1%	1%	

Source: Company reports and J.P. Morgan estimates. Capex forecasts are based on estimates from JPM Telecom Services team.

Prior Estimates

Figure 3: Carrier Capex Historicals and Forecasts

\$ in Millions

U.S. Telcos	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Verizon	17,011	4,201	4,100	4,100	4,100	16,501	4,100	4,200	4,100	4,100	16,500	4,225	4,325	4,225	4,225	17,000
AT&T	22,023	5,089	6,067	6,172	6,172	23,500	5,725	6,025	6,025	5,725	23,500	5,825	5,925	6,025	5,725	23,500
T-Mobile	9,955	2,623	2,483	2,524	2,371	10,001	2,416	2,411	2,447	2,526	9,800	2,425	2,416	2,450	2,528	9,820
U.S Telcos	48,989	11,913	12,650	12,796	12,643	50,002	12,241	12,636	12,572	12,351	49,800	12,475	12,666	12,700	12,478	50,320
Y/Y Change	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Verizon	0%	1%	8%	-5%	-14%	-3%	-2%	2%	0%	0%	0%	1%	5%	3%	-74%	3%
AT&T	0%	14%	19%	17%	-14%	7%	12%	-1%	-2%	-7%	0%	-3%	-2%	5%	-76%	0%
T-Mobile	13%	7%	4%	-4%	-4%	0%	-8%	-3%	-3%	7%	-2%	1%	-1%	-3%	-74%	0%
U.S Telcos	2%	8%	12%	5%	-12%	2%	3%	0%	-2%	-2%	0%	-1%	1%	3%	-75%	1%
Q/Q Change	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Verizon		-12%	-2%	0%	0%		0%	2%	-2%	0%		-74%	2%	-2%	0%	
AT&T		-29%	19%	2%	0%		-7%	5%	0%	-5%		-75%	2%	2%	-5%	
T-Mobile		6%	-5%	2%	-6%		2%	0%	2%	3%		-75%	0%	1%	3%	
U.S Telcos		-17%	6%	1%	-1%		-3%	3%	-1%	-2%		-75%	2%	0%	-2%	

Cable Operators	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Comcast	8,725	1,848	2,091	2,273	2,396	8,607	2,169	2,154	2,160	2,180	8,662	2,172	2,160	2,173	2,198	8,704
Charter	11,659	2,855	2,777	2,794	2,979	11,406	2,439	2,424	2,407	2,235	9,506	2,057	2,018	2,036	2,035	8,147
Cable Operators	20,384	4,703	4,868	5,067	5,375	20,013	4,608	4,578	4,567	4,415	18,168	4,230	4,179	4,209	4,233	16,851
Y/Y Change	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Comcast	5%	13%	9%	-2%	-16%	-1%	17%	3%	-5%	-9%	1%	1%	0%	0%	-75%	0%
Charter	3%	19%	-3%	-8%	-11%	-2%	-15%	-13%	-14%	-25%	-17%	-15%	-16%	-9%	-79%	-14%
Cable Operators	4%	17%	2%	-6%	-13%	-2%	-2%	-6%	-10%	-18%	-9%	-8%	-9%	-5%	-77%	-7%
Q/Q Change	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
Comcast		-35%	13%	9%	5%		-9%	-1%	0%	1%		-75%	-1%	1%	1%	
Charter		-14%	-3%	1%	7%		-18%	-1%	-1%	-7%		-78%	-2%	1%	0%	
Cable Operators		-24%	4%	4%	6%		-14%	-1%	0%	-3%		-77%	-1%	1%	1%	

Source: Company reports and J.P. Morgan estimates. Capex forecasts are based on estimates from JPM Telecom Services team.

Figure 4: Aggregate Carrier Capex Historicals and Forecasts

\$ in Millions

	2025	1Q26	2Q26E	3Q26E	4Q26E	2026E	1Q27E	2Q27E	3Q27E	4Q27E	2027E	1Q28E	2Q28E	3Q28E	4Q28E	2028E
U.S Telcos	48,989	11,913	12,650	12,796	12,643	50,002	12,241	12,636	12,572	12,351	49,800	12,475	12,666	12,700	12,478	50,320
Y/Y % Change	2%	8%	12%	5%	-12%	2%	3%	0%	-2%	-2%	0%	-1%	1%	3%	-75%	1%
Q/Q % Change		-17%	6%	1%	-1%		-3%	3%	-1%	-2%		-75%	2%	0%	-2%	
Cable Operators	20,384	4,703	4,868	5,067	5,375	20,013	4,608	4,578	4,567	4,415	18,168	4,230	4,179	4,209	4,233	16,851
Y/Y % Change	4%	17%	2%	-6%	-13%	-2%	-2%	-6%	-10%	-18%	-9%	-8%	-9%	-5%	-77%	-7%
Q/Q % Change		-24%	4%	4%	6%		-14%	-1%	0%	-3%		-77%	-1%	1%	1%	

Source: Company reports and J.P. Morgan estimates. Capex forecasts are based on estimates from JPM Telecom Services team.

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